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FREE GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

AI Growth Playbook for NZ businesses

Practical ways to win more work, cut the admin and grow without adding headcount. Plain English, no hype, written for owners and managers of small and growing New Zealand businesses.

01 The three levers

02 Ten quick wins

03 A 30/60/90-day plan

The tools got good. The hard part is knowing where to start.

Assistants like ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and Microsoft Copilot can now draft, summarise, sort and answer questions well enough to be useful in everyday work. Automation tools can connect the apps you already pay for. None of that is new on its own. What has changed is that it is now affordable and usable for a business of five people, not just a business of five hundred.

But most small businesses don't need "an AI strategy". They need fewer dropped enquiries, less re-typing, faster replies and a website that brings in work. AI is one tool for that, alongside plain automation and, sometimes, software built around how you work.

What this playbook is

- A practical checklist of changes, ordered from quick and cheap to bigger builds.
- Notes on what you can do yourself and when it's worth getting help.
- A one-page plan you can fill in with your team.

What it isn't

- A sales pitch for tools you don't need.
- A promise that AI will run your business.
- Legal advice. Where privacy matters, we point you to the official sources.

How to use it

Read sections 02 and 03 first. Tick the quick wins that apply to you, pick no more than three, and put them into the 30/60/90-day plan in section 09. Small, finished improvements beat a big plan that never ships.

Almost every useful change pulls one of three levers.

When you look at an idea, ask which lever it pulls. If it doesn't clearly pull one, park it.

LEVER 1

Win more work

Capture every enquiry, reply quickly, follow up consistently, and make it easy to say yes.

- One place where every enquiry lands, whatever the channel.
- An instant acknowledgement, then a real reply the same day.
- Follow-up reminders so quotes don't go quiet.
- A website with a clear next step on every page.

LEVER 2

Spend less time on admin

Stop re-typing, chasing and copying between systems, so people spend their time on customers and the work itself.

- Enter details once and let them flow to quotes, jobs and invoices.
- Automatic reminders for bookings, payments and documents.
- AI to draft emails, summarise calls and tidy notes, with a person checking.

LEVER 3

Serve customers better

Give customers answers, bookings and updates without them having to call you.

- Online booking, quotes or payments.
- Progress updates sent automatically at each stage.
- A client portal or app once you have repeat customers or ongoing jobs.

Ten changes most businesses can make this quarter.

QUICK WIN	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHO
1. One enquiry inbox	Phone messages, emails and web forms all land in one shared inbox or CRM, with an owner for each.	DIY
2. Instant acknowledgement	Every web enquiry gets an automatic, friendly reply saying when you'll be in touch.	DIY
3. Quote follow-up reminders	A reminder fires if a quote hasn't had a reply in a few days, so nothing goes quiet.	DIY
4. AI-drafted replies	Use an approved assistant to draft replies to common questions. A person always reads before sending.	DIY
5. Meeting and call notes	Summarise calls into actions and next steps. Tell people when a call is being recorded or transcribed.	DIY
6. Online booking	Let customers book consultations or jobs into your real calendar, with reminders.	DIY
7. A better enquiry form	A short form that asks the questions you always ask on the first call, and tracks where leads came from.	Get help
8. Connect forms to your systems	Form details flow straight into your CRM, job system or Xero contacts instead of being re-typed.	Get help
9. Automatic job updates	Customers get a text or email when a job is booked, on the way, or complete.	Get help
10. A one-page AI guideline	Which tools are approved, what can and can't be pasted in, and who to ask. See section 07.	DIY

DIY means most owners can set it up with the tools they already have. Get help means it's usually faster and safer with someone who has done it before, especially where systems need connecting.

04 · WHEN OFF-THE-SHELF STOPS FITTING

Signs it's time for software shaped around you.

Off-the-shelf tools are the right starting point for most businesses. They stop fitting when the way you work is a real advantage and the software keeps forcing you to work around it.

Warning signs

- You pay for several subscriptions that each do part of the job.
- Staff keep spreadsheets "on the side" because the system can't do it.
- The same customer exists in three places with three different details.
- Per-seat pricing grows faster than the value you get.

What custom can look like

- A CRM built around how you actually sell and deliver.
- A client portal for bookings, documents and progress.
- An internal app that replaces a pile of spreadsheets.
- An iOS and Android app for your customers or team.

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05 · YOUR WEBSITE SHOULD SELL

A brochure site waits. A smart website works.

01

Clear next step

Every page ends with one obvious action: book, call, or ask a question.

02

Short, smart forms

Ask only what you need for a first conversation. Save the rest for the call.

03

Measure enquiries

Track which pages, searches and ads lead to enquiries, not just visits.

04

Fast on mobile

Many visitors arrive on a phone. Test your own site on yours, on mobile data.

05

Show real work

Projects, photos and named results build more trust than adjectives.

06

Easy for AI to read

Plain descriptions of what you do and where, so search engines and AI assistants can recommend you.

Connect what you already pay for before buying anything new.

Most NZ small businesses already run on Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, plus an accounting system such as Xero. Each of these can talk to other tools, either built in or through an automation service.

Google Workspace

Forms, Sheets, Gmail and Calendar connect easily. Apps Script can automate simple steps, and Gemini features are available in many Workspace plans.

Microsoft 365

Power Automate connects Outlook, Teams, SharePoint and Excel. Copilot can be added to draft and summarise inside the apps your team already uses.

Xero

Xero has an app marketplace and an API, so contacts, quotes and invoices can be created from other systems instead of re-typed.

Five rules that keep automation tidy

- **Map it first.** Write the process down step by step before automating it. If it's messy on paper, it'll be messy automated.
- **One source of truth.** Decide which system "owns" each piece of information, and sync from there.
- **Start small.** Automate one hand-off, run it for a few weeks, then add the next.
- **Keep a human in the loop** for anything a customer sees or anything involving money, at least at first.
- **Write it down.** Keep a simple list of what's automated, who owns it and what to do if it stops.

Tools people commonly use

Zapier, Make and Power Automate for no-code connections; native integrations inside your CRM or job system; and custom code when the volume, logic or reliability needs go beyond what no-code handles well.

Tools are easy. Habits are the work.

Make it safe to try

- Approve one or two tools, ideally business plans that don't use your data for training by default. Check each provider's current terms.
- Run a hands-on session using real tasks from your business, not generic demos.
- Share wins in a team channel so good prompts spread.

A one-page guideline

- Which tools are approved, and for what.
- What must never be pasted in: personal details, health or financial information, passwords, client confidential material.
- A person checks anything AI-written before it reaches a customer.
- Who to ask when unsure.

Privacy Act 2020: the basics to keep in mind

The Privacy Act 2020 applies to almost every NZ business that handles personal information, including when you use AI tools. A few points worth knowing:

- The Act sets out 13 Information Privacy Principles covering how you collect, store, use and share personal information.
- Only collect what you need, tell people why you're collecting it, and keep it secure.
- If a privacy breach has caused or is likely to cause serious harm, you must notify the Privacy Commissioner and the affected people as soon as practicable.
- Sending personal information to providers overseas has its own rules (Information Privacy Principle 12). Check where your tools store and process data.
- The Office of the Privacy Commissioner publishes guidance on using AI tools. Read it before putting customer information into any AI system.

This is general information, not legal advice. See privacy.org.nz for the official guidance.

Where we'd look first, by industry.

Starting points, not prescriptions. Every business is different, which is why we start with a conversation.

Trades & home services

Missed calls while on the tools, quotes that go quiet, and job details re-typed from texts. Start with one enquiry inbox, an after-hours acknowledgement, quote follow-ups, and job updates sent to customers automatically.

Professional services

Onboarding paperwork, document chasing and time spent writing up meetings. Start with a structured intake form, automatic document reminders, AI-assisted meeting notes under a clear guideline, and a client portal once volume justifies it.

Property management

Maintenance requests from many channels, tenant and owner updates, and inspection write-ups. Start with a single request form that routes to the right person, status updates for tenants and owners, and templates for routine communication.

Healthcare & clinics

Booking admin, no-shows and intake forms. Start with online booking and reminders and digital intake. Health information is sensitive: check the Health Information Privacy Code before using any AI tool near patient data.

Hospitality & retail

Bookings, repeat questions, rosters and stock. Start with online bookings or orders, quick answers to common questions on your site, and connecting your point-of-sale to your accounts so numbers aren't re-entered.

09 · YOUR 30/60/90-DAY PLAN

Pick three things. Finish them.

Fill this in with your team. Keep each line specific enough that you'll know when it's done.

WHEN	THE CHANGE	LEVER	OWNER
Days 1-30	e.g. All web enquiries get an instant acknowledgement		
Days 31-60	e.g. Enquiry form feeds the CRM, no re-typing		
Days 61-90	e.g. Team trained, AI guideline signed off		

How we'll know it worked

e.g. replies within the hour, hours of re-typing saved each week

What we'll stop doing

e.g. copying web enquiries into a spreadsheet by hand

Want a hand with any of this?

Mainframe Digital is an Auckland studio building practical AI, automation and software for small and growing NZ businesses: iOS and Android apps, custom business applications, smart websites, workflow automation, and AI setup with team training.

STEP 01 · DISCOVER

A free consultation about your business, your goals and what's slowing you down. We listen first.

STEP 02 · PLAN

We show you a free demo of what we'd build first, then agree a clear plan and scope up front.

STEP 03 · BUILD

We build, test and launch it with you, and keep you in the loop with working results, not jargon.

STEP 04 · SUPPORT

We train your team, look after what we've built and keep improving it as you grow.

Book a free consultation

Tell us about your business and we'll show you a free demo of the two or three things we'd build or automate first. No cost, no obligation.

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